v

Key messages Global Report on ECCE



Key Findings to Emphasize

unesco

Inequalities emerge early, while investment arrives late.

64% of children aged 24–59 months are developmentally on track, falling to just **50%** among the poorest households.

ECCE remains substantially underfunded.

US$41 billion
annual financing gap across 76 low- and middle-income countries, rising to
US$56 billion
by 2030.

Investment is too low and comes too late.

16% of child-related public expenditure goes to children under 6, despite this age group representing around one-third of children.

Where a child is born — and their household income — determines how much is invested in them.

80× higher public investment in children under 6 in Europe and North America than in sub-Saharan Africa, while within countries public fimancing and household costs reinforce existing inequalities.

The youngest and most vulnerable children remain the biggest blind spots.

Financing and monitoring for children under 3, children with disabilities, non-state provision and multisectoral services remain particularly weak. Families often absorb the shortfall: in many sub-Saharan African countries, fees account for almost **90%** of ECCE costs.

MORE MONEY ALONE IS NOT ENOUGH.

Domestic public finance must remain the foundation, backed by legal entitlements, progressive allocation, inclusion and a properly financed workforce. International and innovative finance can complement this investment, but cannot replace it.

Emerging Comm's Messages

"During this period, societies decide, often before children ever enter a classroom, whether inequality will be narrowed or allowed to widen."

"Children who fall behind in these early years never catch up with their peers"

"Financing is … a determinant of social policy and social justice, shaping who is included and who is left behind from a child's very first years."

"Among total ODA disbursements to ECCE in 2023, only 3 of the top 10 recipients were low-income countries"

"Between birth and age 5, children are exceptionally vulnerable to changes in their environments."

"The cost of inaction amounts to an average annual loss of 3 per cent globally, reaching up to 7 per cent in low-income countries."

"When governments do not regulate or finance the non-state sector effectively, disparities in access and learning conditions widen."

From Evidence to Action

Emerging messages from each chapter inform five interlinked recommendations for the Global Report.

unesco

Chapter 1

The state of ECCE and the case for greater investment



5 emerging messages

Chapter 2

Framing the issue of financing



4 emerging messages

Chapter 3

Global, regional and national trends in ECCE financing



5 emerging messages

Chapter 4

Financing approaches to advance equity and inclusion



7 emerging messages

Chapter 5

Financing a diverse, decent and accountable workforce to enhance quality and equity in ECCE



4 emerging messages

Five Priority Recommendations

1 **Lock in multi-year budgets, front-loaded for young children.**

Informed by evidence from: 1 2 3 4 5

2 **End the financing blind spot for children under 3.**

Informed by evidence from: 1 2 3 4

3 **Finance one coordinated, accountable, government-led system.**

Informed by evidence from: 1 2 3 4

4 **Finance the workforce for quality and inclusion.**

Informed by evidence from: 1 3 4 5

5 **Finance inclusion, including by reducing costs for families.**

Informed by evidence from: 1 2 3 4 5

Recommendations

Part III Transformative ECCE: The Way Forward | *Chapter 6. Strategic Recommendations and Policy Pathways*

Priority action	Adequate and predictable	Equitable	Quality-enhancing	Effectively governed
1 Lock in multi-year budgets, front-loaded for young children	✓	✓		✓
2 End the financing blind spot for children under 3	✓	✓		✓
3 Finance one coordinated, accountable, government-led system	✓	✓		✓
4 Finance the workforce for quality and inclusion	✓		✓	
5 Finance inclusion, including by reducing costs for families	✓	✓	✓	

Figure 23: Translating the financing framework into 5 priority actions

Global Report on Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) 2026:

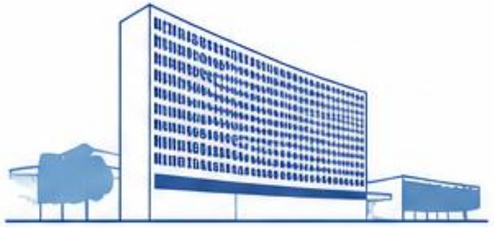
Financing for Equitable and Inclusive Access to Quality ECCE

DATES

19 November 2026
Technical Meeting on the Global Report

20 November 2026
High-Level Policy Dialogue & Global Report Launch
(on the occasion of Universal Children's Day)

VENUE



UNESCO Headquarters
Paris, France
(Room I)

CO-PUBLISHERS

unesco

unicef

OECD

OBJECTIVES

- Launch the 2026 Global Report
- Present the key findings and recommendations
- Foster high-level policy dialogue on financing quality ECCE
- Mobilize political commitment and partnerships for SDG 4.2

EXPECTED PARTICIPANTS

- Ministers and senior government representatives
- UN agencies and development partners
- Researchers and academics
- Civil society organizations
- Youth representatives
- Philanthropic organizations and private sector partners

EVENT HIGHLIGHTS

- High-level policy dialogue
- Report presentation
- Youth engagement activities
- Premiere of the **GOBELINS** animated storytelling project
- Networking and media opportunities



Thank you

Learn more:

www.unesco.org/education

Follow **@unesco** on social media